

Enhancing Attraction Experiences Through Home Sharing: Evidence from Customer Review Analytics

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Abstract

Customer experiences largely define the success of service operations. As home sharing continues to change how consumers travel and penetrate local markets, we study the impact of home sharing on customer experiences at local travel attractions. Our empirical strategy hinges on the staggered rollout of home sharing across attractions at times. We first found that home sharing positively affects customer experiences at attractions. Using large-scale property-level customer reviews, we then traced down individual review-level content features describing host support that can explain the impact of home sharing on attraction experiences. Specifically, the mechanism centers on local travel support from hosts who provide saving tips, share attraction knowledge, and facilitate travel planning while consumers stay at their home sharing properties. We further explore the intriguing heterogeneity of the home sharing impact, unveiling the unintended consequence of overtourism, especially at nationally renowned attractions and during peak season. Finally and fortunately, host support manifests to mitigate the negative impact of home sharing and remains a potential solution to address overtourism. Collectively, these findings add evidence to the sophisticated roles of home sharing in local markets and provide timely implications on customer experience management to service operation practitioners and attraction stakeholders.

Keywords

Sharing Economy, Home Sharing, Travel Attractions, Customer Experiences, Host Support, Difference-in-differences, Propensity Score Matching, Text Mining

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1 Introduction

The proliferation of the sharing economy has enabled individuals to use under-utilized assets via fee-based sharing platforms (Eckhardt et al., 2019; Filippas et al., 2020). Home sharing represents a distinctive model within the sharing economy by allowing property owners to monetize their under-utilized living spaces. This aspect differentiates home sharing from other sharing economy models, which typically focus on the temporary exchange or use of movable assets (e.g., cars in ridesharing). The impact of home sharing manifests on both microeconomic and macroeconomic levels. Microeconomically, home sharing allows individual hosts to monetize their underused resources, converting private residences into revenue-generating assets and facilitating cultural exchanges that enrich the travel experience (Shi et al., 2019). Macroeconomically, it influences real estate markets, tourism, and local economies by expanding a city's accommodation capacity without additional construction, thus making travel more

affordable and accessible (Barron et al., 2021). Moreover, it distributes tourist spending across a wider range of local businesses and neighborhoods, potentially promoting more balanced economic growth (Farronato and Fradkin, 2022).

As a poster child of the sharing economy, home sharing has led the way in popularity, experiencing exponential growth globally since late 2000. For example, since its launch in 2008, the world's largest home sharing platform, Airbnb, has grown to have 8 million properties in over 100,000 cities and 220 countries (Airbnb, 2024). It is widely recognized that home

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sharing has revolutionized the way people travel and experience attractions. Despite the increasing prevalence of home sharing, only recently has its impact on local markets started to receive extensive research attention. Studies have examined various impacts of home sharing—disruptions or benefits—to hotels (Zervas et al., 2017), local housing markets (Barron et al., 2021), small business, and employment (Alyakoob and Rahman, 2022), as well as communities and neighborhoods (Filippas and Horton, 2017).

In this paper, we focus on an important yet under-explored research area: the impact of home sharing on local travel attractions (attractions, hereafter). Different from other local markets, attractions have unique service operation characteristics such as a heavy emphasis on customer experience (Botha, 2018), demand deeply influenced by seasonal cycles that require flexible accommodation supply (Pike, 2012), and vulnerability to societal impacts such as local residents' attitudes (Gursoy et al., 2009). *On the one hand*, home sharing has become a popular alternative to traditional hotels and offers a unique opportunity for consumers to experience attractions in a more authentic way (Alyakoob and Rahman, 2022). *On the other hand*, the quality of the experience can vary greatly depending on the host and the property. While many hosts provide personalized recommendations and create a positive experience, there are risks involved, such as safety concerns, unexpected situations, and inconsistency in standards (Chen and Tussyadiah, 2021). Unlike hotels, where the level of service and amenities are standardized, home sharing can vary greatly in quality. Consumers might have a bad experience if the home they stay in is not up to their expectations or if the host is not responsive to their needs.

Amid the debate on home sharing, we are particularly interested in understanding how home sharing would influence attractions from the customer experience perspective, given that a dominant portion of home sharing is offering both the stay and the host service to consumers visiting attractions. We studied three research questions: (a) Does home sharing affect the customer experience at attractions? (b) What are the possible mechanisms that drive the effect? (c) Would the impact of home sharing on customer experience be at the cost of attractions? Answers to these questions are less documented in prior literature, but will provide valuable insights to understand the sophisticated impact of home sharing and inform service operations and public policymaking toward the goal of balancing the benefit of home sharing without costing the public welfare in local markets. Our investigation is grounded in the theory of customer experience management (Becker and Jaakkola, 2020; Lemon and Verhoef, 2016), which emphasizes that the interaction between service providers and customers is a critical channel for achieving an enhanced customer experience.

We utilize an empirical opportunity of home sharing's staggered rollout in the major attractions across cities of China at different times. Attractions that experienced home sharing are the affected group in our empirical design, while those without home sharing but mirroring the affected attractions are

the unaffected group. We collected large-scale data on 38,277 unique home sharing properties near 2503 attractions from six major travel markets in China between January 2012 and June 2019 (a total of 90 months). Our analysis hinges on an integrated empirical strategy: a difference-in-differences (DID) specification using a propensity score matching (PSM) sample and a text mining method using content features in consumer reviews to unveil the mechanism behind the home sharing's impact. We deploy a plethora of analyses, such as the two-way fixed effects estimators with heterogeneous treatment effects given by de Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020) and a parallel trends test before treatment occurs using the relative time model to check the robustness of our findings while ruling out alternative explanations. For easy reference, we have furnished Table A1 of Section A1 in the E-Companion for an overview of the analyses.

Our analyses yield several important findings. First, we found the growth of home sharing results in better customer experience at attractions. Quantitatively, as home sharing grows by 10%, the customer experience at attractions, measured by the average customer attraction rating, improves by a significant 0.7 (on a 5-star scale). This finding demonstrates a positive externality from home sharing to local markets (attractions in our case), adding evidence to inform the debate about home sharing's impact (e.g., Alyakoob and Rahman, 2022; Chen and Tussyadiah, 2021) and lending support to the role of home sharing in changing consumer perception about the attractions (Shi et al., 2019) and destination image construction (Lalicic et al., 2021).

Second and more importantly, we unveil clear evidence of the mechanism behind such an experience-enhancing effect of home sharing: the travel support from local hosts (host support, hereafter). Our evidence consists of observations from home sharing properties with host presence (i.e., hosts stay with consumers in the shared properties) and the consumer reviews-informed content features about host support. *On the former*, we first found that the positive impact of home sharing on customer experience magnifies at attractions, in which a higher proportion of home sharing properties have host presence. A further breakdown of home sharing properties by host presence shows that home sharing properties with host presence experience a significant increase in customer experience, while those without host presence experience an insignificant increase. *On the latter*, we utilize a text mining approach to analyze home sharing review-level content features. We found specific host support aspects received by consumers that significantly drive their experience: saving tips, attraction knowledge, and travel planning. These findings speak to the mechanism of local travel support by hosts as a main driver and contributor to the increase in customer experience.

Our third finding concentrates on the unintended impact of home sharing. We began with testing the heterogeneity of home sharing's impact across attractions and seasons. We found that the positive impact on customer experience weakens at nationally renowned attractions and during peak

seasons, for which home sharing tends to bring an influx of consumers to visit the attractions. Following this clue, we further found an inverted U-shaped effect of attraction visits on customer experience through mediation analysis. The result shows that the influx of attraction visits (in the form of the quadratic form) largely discounts customer experience at attractions, a sign of overtourism. A follow-up analysis indeed shows that home sharing tends to attract more attraction visits to nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons. Fortunately, for attractions with more home sharing properties that have host presence, the negative consequence of overtourism is mitigated. These findings demonstrate the importance of host support in customer experience management specific to the context of attraction service operation.

Finally, we reveal the nuanced role of host support between local gems and nationally renowned attractions. Specifically, for local gems, host support amplifies home sharing's positive effect by offering personalized recommendations and directing visitors to lesser-known spots that are not widely publicized. By assisting travelers in seeking authentic, less crowded experiences and guiding them to discover local charm and off-the-beaten-path locations, hosts enrich attraction customer experiences with deeper cultural insights that surpass the offerings of traditional guidebooks or online platforms. In contrast, for nationally renowned attractions, which are often characterized by standardized and commercialized experiences, host support reduces the promotional impact of home sharing by redirecting attraction customers' attention away from overcrowded sites. This helps attractions balance tourism flows, alleviating overtourism challenges at major landmarks while channeling more visitors toward less-visited local gems. Such redirection balances the benefits of home sharing across different types of attractions, fostering more sustainable and rewarding travel experiences. These insights highlight the differential impact of host support and emphasize its crucial role in enhancing the authenticity and sustainability of the tourism experience.

Our paper positions itself on an under-researched area of home sharing's impact on customer experiences at attractions. While prior studies have extensively explored the effects of home sharing on the hotel industry (Filippas et al., 2020) and the housing markets (Chen et al., 2022), limited research has been conducted on its direct impact on consumer experiences, specifically how it affects the customer experience at tourist attractions. Our paper contributes to the literature with undocumented findings and insights in terms of the mechanism of host support behind home sharing's impact on attraction experiences, informed by review text analyses, the intriguing heterogeneity of home sharing's impact across different attractions, and the unintended consequences of overtourism and the potential solution to this problem through host support. In terms of the theoretical and practical implications, our findings extend primarily the theory of customer experience management to incorporate the unique findings in the sharing economy. By doing so, we provide a framework that can

be used to evaluate home sharing's impact on attractions. We also offer evidence-based insights that can guide policymakers, local businesses, and platform operators in maximizing the home sharing benefits while mitigating the unintended consequences of overtourism. This is particularly relevant for developing attraction operation strategies and regulatory frameworks toward the healthy growth of home sharing. For example, attractions can collaborate with local home sharing hosts to implement bundled travel packages, such as deals that combine lodging with exclusive access to attractions. Attractions can also offer host training programs to empower hosts as knowledgeable ambassadors for promoting local sites. Furthermore, leveraging technology platforms to integrate booking systems across travel segments, such as home sharing and attraction visits, or launching pilot programs to assess collaboration performance, can further facilitate partnerships. Lastly, implementing capacity controls at nationally renowned attractions during peak seasons, coupled with collaborative approaches between local hosts and policymakers, can effectively balance visitor distribution and foster sustainable tourism.

2 Related Literature

Our work is closely related to two streams of literature: the effects of home sharing on local markets and customer experience management in home sharing. By investigating the impact of home sharing on customer experience at attractions, our paper contributes to the literature with unique insights, including under-documented findings and insights in terms of the mechanism of host support behind home sharing's impact on attraction experiences informed by review text analyses, the intriguing heterogeneity of home sharing's impact across different attractions, and the unintended consequences of overtourism and the potential solution to this problem through host support. These new insights contribute to the literature and enrich our understanding of the sophisticated role of home sharing in local markets.

2.1 Effects of Home Sharing on Local Markets

Our study first adds to the literature on the impact of home sharing on local markets. As home sharing continues to proliferate, an emerging body of work has explored the changes made to the local markets by home sharing. On the positive side, Alyakoob and Rahman (2022) show that Airbnb customers benefit from local restaurants with more patronage from visitors. Fang et al. (2016) highlighted the job creation in the local tourism industry due to the influx of tourists using Airbnb. On the negative side, Chen et al. (2022) found that an increase in Airbnb properties drives up local rents and house prices, raising concerns about home sharing's disruption of housing affordability. Filippas and Horton (2017) suggested that Airbnb hosts impose costs such as noise, disturbances, and safety concerns on local communities due to residential

spaces being rented out to strangers. Thus, there are inconclusive discussions about the role of home sharing in local markets.

Unlike previous literature, we focus on the under-studied market of travel attractions, which are centrally related to many local economic sectors such as lodging (hotels), transportation, restaurants, retail, and more. In particular, positioning lodging at the core of holistic attraction experiences remains an important perspective in the literature. Several studies have directly compared the performance between hotels and home sharing (e.g., Zervas et al., 2017) and how hotels can respond to the disruption of home sharing (e.g., Liu et al., 2023). The collective findings are that home sharing has been shown to outperform all types of hotel classes based on experiential attributes. We delve deeper into the experiential attributes by investigating the impact of home sharing on consumer experiences at attractions and the mechanism behind it. Objectively, we advocate that home sharing platforms have the potential to shape positive consumer experiences at attractions and should be incorporated into the service operation of any attraction. However, we also underline the potential negative impact of home sharing on causing overtourism issues to the attractions, especially at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons, which are rarely discussed in prior literature.

Relevant to our research, Shi et al. (2019) indicate that home sharing significantly influences the authenticity and cultural aspects of customer experiences, which are closely tied to their perceptions of attraction images. This pioneering tourism study surveys tourists using questionnaires about the correlation between home sharing stay experiences, tourism experiences, and destination image perceptions. They state that home sharing is very closely related to tourists' perceptions of attraction images because it influences the authenticity and cultural aspects of customer experiences. Our study differs from Shi et al. (2019) in several important aspects: estimating the impact of home sharing using a quasi-experiment design that is different from questionnaire-based surveys; providing direct evidence on the role of local host support on customer attraction experience through review text analyses; and unveiling the important implications of empowering the local home sharing to not only enhance customer experience but also mitigate the negative effects of overtourism at attractions.

2.2 Customer Experience Management in Home Sharing

We draw upon customer experience management as a theoretical lens to understand the mechanism behind home sharing's impact on local markets. Customer experience management emphasizes the comprehensive nature of customer interactions, including cognitive, emotional, behavioral, sensorial, and social dimensions (Becker and Jaakkola, 2020). This theoretical framework helps us understand how customer experiences are shaped and managed across different service

operation contexts, especially from home sharing to attractions. As they explore attractions, consumers interact with authentic service providers (i.e., local hosts) who are different from those in traditional lodging corporations such as hotels.

Such interactions present unique opportunities and challenges for customer experience management. *On the one hand*, the majority of the literature agrees that home sharing offers a unique channel where local hosts can co-create consumer experiences with tourists. For example, Liu et al. (2021) found that customers value host hospitality and social interaction more than the physical environment in home sharing. Cheng (2016) pointed out that home sharing emphasizes authentic "living like a local" experiences, making consumers benefit from unique aspects like social interactions with hosts. Shi et al. (2019) indicated that home sharing stays offer enhanced interactions with hosts, providing a unique experience compared to mainstream accommodations such as hotels. *On the other hand*, interactions with locals can be a double-edged sword for customers, providing both positive and negative experiences. While some interactions may be enriching and memorable, others can be uncomfortable or even hostile, leading to dissatisfaction and negative consequences. While home sharing platforms like Airbnb offer tourists the opportunity to stay in local neighborhoods and experience the attractions "as a local," these interactions may not always be positive. For example, Gago and Paniagua (2019) found that the growth of home sharing in Barcelona led to conflicts between tourists and residents, particularly in areas with a high concentration of home sharing units. Eckhardt et al. (2019) highlighted the challenges of sharing economy in transforming customer experiences, especially in building customer trust. Unlike traditional service operation contexts where customers may develop strong personal relationships with a specific service provider, the digitalized matching and vast number of peer participants on the home sharing platforms make establishing close relationships challenging.

Our study adds to the literature an evidence-based mechanism of host support. We consider travel support from local hosts an important channel of customer experience management. We draw upon the intimacy theory to understand customer experience management from host support that can shape consumer experience at attractions. Indeed, we disclose that attractions with more home sharing properties that have host presence experience better ratings from consumers. A further extraction of consumer review-level content features speaks to the exact approaches of customer experience management by home sharing hosts, including saving tips, attraction knowledge, and travel planning. More importantly, these service aspects can mitigate the potential negative impact of home sharing amid overtourism concerns, especially at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons. These findings further the literature by providing a complete understanding of the role of host support in customer experience management at attractions.

3 Hypothesis Development

Sharing economy services run on technology-mediated platforms that match suppliers and customers for on-demand services. Compared with incumbent businesses that provide similar services, sharing economy services feature local support and convenience (Lalicic et al., 2021), low customer search costs (Zervas et al., 2017), low barriers to entry (Einav et al., 2016), and networked markets with widely dispersed users (Sundararajan, 2017). In particular, home sharing features an asset-free, low-fixed-cost business model and personalized services (Benjaafar and Hu, 2020). These comparative advantages make it possible for home sharing to scale rapidly within a short period.

Not surprisingly, as home sharing continues to grow, it is most commonly situated near travel attractions. An important yet untapped question is how home sharing impacts these attractions from a customer experience management perspective. We formally hypothesize the relationship between home sharing and customer experience, with a focus on the mechanism of host support as an important channel of customer experience management. We start with conjecturing home sharing's impact on customer experience at attractions. We then conjecture the mechanisms driving this impact—local travel support from home sharing hosts—from three important perspectives: host presence, individual aspects of host support, and the unique value of host support in mitigating the negative impact of home sharing. These conjectures depict a clear theoretical framework to help us understand the sophisticated roles of home sharing in attraction experience through customer experience management via local host support.

3.1 Impact of Home Sharing on Customer Experience

Drawing upon the customer experience management theory, which underscores the comprehensive nature of customer interactions encompassing multiple dimensions (Lemon and Verhoef, 2016), we explore the distinctive impact of home sharing on customer experiences. This theoretical framework allows us to delve into how home sharing uniquely enhances customer experiences at local attractions. A report by Airbnb (2024) analyzing over 2.8 million host guidebooks shows that customers most appreciate hosts' recommendations of local attractions. A homeowner can also personally lead a tour of the attraction as a courtesy or at some extra cost. For example, Airbnb has launched a new feature called Airbnb Experiences that allows customers to book "immersive" travel experiences, such as city tours directly with the hosts or other locals (Airbnb, 2024). Such information and assistance from local hosts help mitigate information asymmetry in travel, which is often unavoidable when visiting new attractions.

The home sharing platform provides a unique channel where consumers can co-create authentic attraction experiences through interactions with participating groups. Compared to the traditional hotel industry, the benefits of home

sharing manifest the most in the unique experience, such as social interaction with hosts, neighbors, and other users, as well as the entire travel process (Cheng, 2016). Researchers argue that customers value host hospitality and social interaction more than the physical environment in home sharing (Liu et al., 2021). Recent work has also examined how the host-customer relationship affects visitors' experiences and impacts perceptions of attraction image (Lalicic et al., 2021; Shi et al., 2019). For instance, the home sharing experience influences the authenticity and cultural aspects of tourist experiences (Shi et al., 2019).

Given its peer-to-peer sharing nature, the home sharing platform highlights the interactive element during consumer stays. Benefiting from the interactions with locals, customers of home sharing can potentially obtain a better experience of an attraction, plan their visits more effectively, streamline travel logistics, save time and money, and have better experiences. This is also why many customers prefer to stay at Airbnb rather than at hotels (Young et al., 2017). Filippas and Horton (2017) point out that hotels have long strived to emulate such kinds of personal and customized interactions. We thus expect that home sharing elevates the customer experience at attractions by allowing tourists to interact with locals and their authentic households. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

- H1.** The growth of home sharing improves customer experience at a local travel attraction.

3.2 Role of Local Host Support

Local host support is an important channel of customer experience management. While several literatures have suggested local travel support from hosts is valued by consumers when visiting attractions (Shi et al., 2019), host support as a general concept remains less understood in terms of how hosts shape consumer experiences at attractions, what aspects of host support are valued by consumers, and what role host support may play if home sharing involves negative impact to attractions. We fill the void by decomposing the effect of host support and conjecture the respective role of host support in separate hypotheses.

3.2.1 Host Presence in Shared Homes. Consumers can rent a home sharing property with host presence (shared homes) or without host presence (entire home). Hosts can support consumers without physical presence (via emails, phone calls, messages, etc.). However, host presence in a shared home sharing property makes face-to-face interactions more likely. If host support holds in affecting customer experience at attractions, we would expect a stronger effect of home sharing on attraction experience with more shared properties with host presence.

Intimacy theory is closely related to customer experience management and helps understand the impact of host presence

in shared properties on customer experience at attractions. Originating from leisure and social psychology (Gabb, 2008), intimacy is defined as “a knowledge of the core of something, an understanding of the inmost parts, that which is indicative of one’s deepest nature and marked by close physical, mental, and social association” (Oden, 1974). Intimacy with an attraction is created through intensive interactions with local objects and individuals, fostering meaningful consumer interactions (Trauer & Ryan, 2005).

Utilizing the theoretical lens of intimacy theory, we argue that intimacy is the core of home sharing stay experience and that intimacy elements in home sharing stay experience would enhance customer experiences with an attraction. Intimacy in tourism is understood as “an embodied experience that arouses a sense of closeness and a story about a shared experience” (Conran, 2011). A consumer would experience a high level of intimacy with an attraction when he/she is introduced to the attraction by someone who has “intense, longitudinal experiences of, and association with” the attraction (Trauer & Ryan, 2005). Consumers can experience common areas in local household homes, communicate with hosts and their families, and exchange attraction information. Consequently, a home sharing property that carries a sense of shared experience with locals can potentially disclose a high level of intimacy with an attraction. Thus, we hypothesize the following:

H2. The impact of home sharing on customer experience is greater for attractions where more homes are shared between hosts and customers with host presence.

3.2.2 Specific Host Support. The most prominent difference in service operation between home sharing and incumbent services such as hotels may lie in the service providers themselves. In contrast to the traditional service offered by hotel staff, home sharing hosts excel at providing personalized touch and customized service since they serve customers on a one-on-one basis. In home sharing’s peer-to-peer setting, host and customer interaction is often one-on-one and highly personal. A customer can ask the hosts for insider tips on where to go, when to go, what to see, and how to enjoy local attractions.

The personalized touch offered by hosts can enhance the overall enjoyment of attractions and increase the likelihood of positive attraction reviews and return visits. For example, by providing recommendations for local attractions and activities, hosts can help customers discover hidden gems and experience attractions in a more authentic way. An insightful introduction to local culture and traditions can make the travel experience more meaningful and memorable to the consumers. Hosts can also help consumers navigate unfamiliar surroundings to avoid common tourist traps. By offering tips on transportation and dining options, providing cash coupons to attractions, and assisting with other logistical matters, hosts can help consumers feel more comfortable and confident while exploring the attractions with less stress and more satisfaction. In sum, local travel support from home sharing hosts can positively

impact the customer experience at attractions by providing personalized recommendations, insights into local culture, and logistical support. Accordingly, we hypothesize the following:

H3. Local host support in terms of saving tips, attraction knowledge, and travel planning positively affects customer experience at attractions.

3.2.3 Mitigating Negative Experience. Although home sharing expands the local lodging capacity by accommodating more visitors who may not be accommodated by traditional lodging, the excess capacity can exacerbate the problem of overtourism (Koens et al., 2018). Without proper planning, permits, or taxes, more visits may add extra burdens to attractions amid the surging demand in this situation (Mihalic, 2020). According to a joint study between the World Travel & Tourism Council and McKinsey & Company,¹ issues such as traffic problems and overcrowding that are caused by overtourism pose serious challenges to the carrying capacity of attractions and degrade the consumer experience. For example, popular travel destinations such as Amsterdam, Barcelona, and Venice are reported to be the most exposed to the overtourism problem during peak travel seasons due to home sharing’s presence.² In other words, the positive effect of home sharing on the consumer experience would be reduced by overtourism, especially during peak seasons and at nationally renowned attractions.

If local host support is the core mechanism behind enhanced customer experience at attractions, we conjecture it could play a crucial role in mitigating the negative effects of overtourism and improving the experience for all customers. By guiding customers to plan attraction visits smartly, finding discounted tickets during off-peak attraction hours, and providing insights about attraction visits, local hosts can help customers navigate the crowds without discounting the attraction experience at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons that often face overtourism concerns. Hosts can offer personalized recommendations and direct visitors to local gems—lesser-known spots cherished by local residents—as well as suggest off-peak times for visiting major landmarks. This approach allows for a more balanced distribution of traffic, enhancing the travel experience for both types of attractions. For travelers seeking more authentic and less crowded experiences, hosts may shift focus to local gems where host support can have a more significant impact.

Relatedly, insightful hosts can offer guidance that extends beyond basic recommendations and logistics. By helping travelers discover local charm, gain deeper cultural insights, and explore lesser-known paths, host support transcends the limitations of guidebooks, offering unique value to the travel experience. Such personal interactions and communications are facilitated when customers stay with local hosts in their home sharing properties. Therefore, we hypothesize the following:

H4. Local host support can help reduce the negative customer experience at attractions due to overtourism.

4 Research Context

4.1 Empirical Data and Measures

Our data is collected from multiple sources. First, we obtained home sharing property data from Xiaozhu (xiaozy.com), the largest peer-to-peer home sharing platform in China. Launched in July 2012, Xiaozhu has more than 800,000 home sharing properties in 700 cities worldwide as of November 2019.³ It was known as “Airbnb in China.” Our sample comprises home sharing properties in six major metropolitan areas: Beijing, Shanghai, Hangzhou, Suzhou, Chengdu, and Chongqing, which not only represent the largest home sharing markets in the nation but also are best known for their extensive attraction availability and vibrant travel industry. Collectively, these cities provide an excellent context for us to observe the staggered rollout of home sharing across local attractions.

Similar to prior studies (e.g., Zervas et al., 2017), the staggered rollout of home sharing properties across attractions at different times provides useful variations for the empirical analysis of home sharing’s impact. To better understand the growth pattern of home sharing in China, we have presented the number of home sharing properties by year and city in Table A3 of Section A3 in the E-Companion. As Table A3 shows, home sharing had a humble beginning in 2012 (the inception year of Xiaozhu in China), with only 21 properties. By the end of our study period, this number had grown to 38,277. For each home sharing property near these attractions, we collected publicly available data on property characteristics, such as geographic coordinates, customer reviews about home sharing, and whether the accommodation at the property is shared between the host and the customer.

We also collected data on local travel attractions from Qunar (qunar.com), the leading online travel platform in China. With 600 million users as of November 2019, Qunar has been a dominant player in China’s online travel service industry, where customers can purchase admission tickets to attractions. The attractions are highly diverse, ranging from the Great Wall in Beijing to the Giant Panda Breeding Research Base in Chengdu. These attractions are either culture-rich destinations or natural scenery sites. Qunar is commissioned by the attractions to sell admission tickets and remains a primary ticket sales portal on the Chinese search engine Baidu. It archives the number of tickets sold with redemption verified by attractions at the time of admission. For each attraction, we obtained the redemption-verified sales of admission tickets, the associated average review rating (i.e., the measure of customer experience at attractions), the level of the attraction designated by the Ministry of Culture and Tourism in the country (e.g., nationally renowned attractions and regular attractions), and the customer reviews and geographic coordinates of each attraction.

We construct a panel dataset merging the attraction and home sharing data at the attraction by year-month level (i.e., the unit of analysis). The data include 2503 attractions across

six cities observed over 90 months from January 2012 (the inception year of home sharing in China) to June 2019 (the end of the study period). This relatively large time window allows us to observe the staggering growth of home sharing properties across attractions over time. During our study period, 660 attractions experienced home sharing rollout, while 1843 attractions never experienced home sharing rollout.

Using the geographic coordinates, we calculated the distance between an attraction and each of the home sharing properties surrounding the attraction. Following the literature (e.g., Shoval et al., 2011), we use a 5-kilometer radius as a useful vicinity to define the vicinity of attractions with respect to the preferred public and alternative transportation accessibility and the commute time spent by customers during travel. Within each attraction’s vicinity, we aggregated the number of home sharing properties (i.e., supply) in each month.

Table A2 presents the variable definitions and summary statistics. Our dependent variable is the average monthly customer experience at an attraction (*Attraction Experience*). The primary independent variable is *log Home Share*, the number of home sharing properties that have appeared at an attraction each month. We identify the rollout time of a home sharing property using its first published reviews by customers. Note that the customer review is time-stamped (with dates) and actually stay-verified. Such a measure is commonly used in prior marketing literature to study the sharing economy’s entry (e.g., Barron et al., 2021). We further study the mechanism of the home sharing impact using variables on local travel support such as *High Host Presence* (whether the attraction has a higher proportion of shared properties with host presence than the median of all attractions in a city) and specific host support, including helping save time and money, introducing local attraction knowledge, and providing travel plans (*Saving Tips Ratio*, *Attraction Knowledge Ratio*, and *Travel Planning Ratio*, measured by the review ratio in each topic). Section 4.2 provides the text mining process in detail to extract content features from consumer reviews to obtain these host support aspects.

We include attraction characteristics such as *National Attraction* and *Peak Season* to further estimate the heterogeneity of the home sharing impact across locations and seasonality. For the former, we categorize all attractions into two groups: nationally renowned attractions and local gems. This classification follows the Ministry of Culture and Tourism’s attraction rating scheme, with nationally renowned attractions designated as 1 and local gems not officially rated but recognized and valued by local residents as 0. For seasonality, given that cities exhibit distinct seasonal patterns, we use *Peak Season* as a dummy variable to capture the seasonality specific to each city (*Peak Season* = 1 for the months that a city has a higher volume of visits than the average monthly visits of the year). We also use other attraction characteristics such as attraction visits (*log Attraction Visits*, measured by the number of admission tickets to attractions sold online at

Table 1. Keyword example mentions in three topics of host support.

Topic	Keyword examples
<i>Saving tips</i>	Cash coupon, bus card, three-day travel pass card, suggesting ways to save time and money including how to plan travel routes, take a taxi, get a coupon, line up, etc.
<i>Attraction knowledge</i>	Telling the history and culture of attractions, taking consumers on tours, suggesting different types of attractions based on personalized demand of customers such as kid-friendly, classical, must-see, and interesting attractions, etc.
<i>Travel planning</i>	Helping make a travel plan, answering questions patiently, introducing suitable attractions, trip modes, useful attraction apps, etc.

Qunar), attraction reviews (*log Attraction Reviews*), the cumulative attraction visits (*Cum. Attraction Visits*) and attraction experience (*Cum. Attraction Experience*), the Internet search volumes of each attraction and other three home sharing platforms (i.e., Tujia, Muniiao, and Airbnb China) (*log Attraction Search Volume*, *log Tujia Search Volume*, *log Muniiao Search Volume*, and *log Airbnb China Search Volume*), the number of reviews-verified hotel stays nearby (a proxy for tourism demand, *log Hotel Stays*), the time-invariant attraction admission ticket price (*log Attraction Price*), and the perceived home sharing price for each attraction (*Perceived Home Sharing Price*, measured by the ratio of positive price-related home sharing reviews to all the price-related reviews for each attraction). A detailed explanation of the measurement construction can be found in Section 4.8 of the E-Companion. For certain variables, we take the logarithm of variables using $\log(\text{value} + 1)$ to cope with nonlinearity and skewed distributions and denote them using “log” throughout the paper.

4.2 Text Mining on Home Sharing Review Texts

To achieve a fine-grained understanding of local travel support from home sharing hosts, we present evidence of specific host support aspects applauded by customers from their home sharing consumer reviews. We utilize text mining to extract topics about local travel support from hosts in each home sharing review. Our approach includes three primary steps. First, we capture all home sharing reviews that mention hosts. We use a wide scope of keywords such as “landlord,” “owner,” and “host” to identify home sharing reviews that contain these keywords. This process is repeated multiple times to ensure a comprehensive identification of all home sharing reviews with the mention of hosts.

Second, from the extracted home sharing reviews, we analyze the frequency of keywords to identify the predominant types of travel support provided by hosts. Using a keyword-based text mining method, we decompose the review texts into individual keywords and calculate their frequency. By aggregating and analyzing these keywords and their corresponding frequency, we identify the main types of support provided by hosts.

Finally, among the identified main types of support provided by hosts, we summarize the various aspects of host support related to attractions into three representative types:

Saving tips, *Attraction knowledge*, and *Travel planning*. These categories are determined based on the keyword relevance and recurrence in the extracted reviews. Table 1 provides examples of keywords associated with these host support topics. Specifically, *Saving Tips* refers to advice provided by hosts on how to save money and time while touring attractions. *Attraction Knowledge* includes host-provided information about the historical and cultural significance of attractions. *Travel Planning* involves consultations with hosts to plan trips that align with customer needs. To validate that the identified types of host support are indeed related to attractions, we examine phrases that explicitly mention travel activities, tourist sites, and local attractions. Using the keywords corresponding to the three representative topics, we classify all the extracted home sharing reviews accordingly.

Through text mining, we provide a detailed analysis of how home sharing hosts support attraction travel, highlighting the key areas of host support that customers appreciate the most. We then aggregate the number of home sharing reviews corresponding to these three topics at the attraction and month levels (units of analysis). This process enabled us to derive three variables depicting specific types of host support that enhance customer experiences at attractions.

5 Model Specification

The variation in the proliferation of home sharing across attractions at different times offers an empirical opportunity for us to examine the impacts of home sharing on customer experience. Insofar as the rollout of home sharing was only in some attractions of the sampled cities, these attractions serve as the “treatment group” affected by home sharing (affected group), while those comparable to the affected group but unaffected by home sharing rollout serve as the “control group” (unaffected group).

To identify comparable attractions, we employed a propensity score matching (PSM, hereafter) approach to construct a sample of attractions with similar pre-trend (before home sharing’s rollout) characteristics for the affected and unaffected groups. PSM helps address the selection concern by accounting for covariates that predict an attraction receiving the treatment (the rollout of home sharing in our case) and ensure the affected and unaffected attractions are comparable before the treatment. For operationalization, we first ran a

Table 2. Comparison between unaffected and affected attractions.

Variables	Unaffected attractions		Affected attractions		t-Statistics	
	Mean	SD	Mean	SD	Diff. (SE)	p
National Attraction	0.211	0.408	0.227	0.420	0.016(0.034)	0.624
log Attraction Price	0.793	1.619	0.832	1.654	0.039(0.133)	0.769
log Attraction Search Volume	2.973	3.921	2.994	4.050	0.021(0.323)	0.948
log Hotel Stays	0.361	1.293	0.308	1.194	−0.053(0.101)	0.599
Cum. Attraction Visits	1.012	0.559	1.063	0.590	0.050(0.047)	0.280
Cum. Attraction Experience	4.192	0.737	4.192	0.758	0.000(0.061)	0.993

logistic regression at the attraction level using the mean values of the observed attraction characteristics to predict the probability of an attraction experiencing home sharing. These characteristics include the level of attractions, the attraction price, the search volume of attractions on the Internet, the number of purchase-verified hotel reviews nearby, and the cumulative reviews and ratings of attractions.

The matched samples are balanced, with 304 attractions in the affected group and 304 attractions in the unaffected group. Table 2 compares the affected and unaffected attractions in the PSM sample. The t-statistics suggest that, on average, the affected attractions are not significantly different from the unaffected attractions in terms of observed characteristics.

Our identification strategy hinges on a difference-in-differences (DID, hereafter) specification using the PSM sample. Using this approach, we estimate the impact of home sharing on customer experience when the rollout of home sharing properties changes over time and between the affected and unaffected attractions. For attraction i in year-month t :

$$\text{Attraction Experience}_{it} = \beta \cdot \log \text{HomeShare}_{it} + \mu_i + \nu_t + \xi \cdot w_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where $\text{Attraction Experience}_{it}$ represents the primary dependent variable, measuring customer experience at attractions. The term $\log \text{Home Share}$ is the key regressor. Its estimated coefficient, β , captures home sharing's impact. In the DID strategy, the first difference is taken using the attraction fixed effects μ_i , which allows for time-invariant differences in customer experience between affected attractions and unaffected attractions. The second difference is taken over time using year-month fixed effects ν_t , which allows for unobserved time-varying customer experience differences that are common across attractions. We also include city-specific time trends w_{it} . The purpose is to control for unobserved city-level trends that differ from city to city. To immunize our findings from such contamination, we construct a variable of time trends for each city and include them in our main specification. We cluster robust standard errors at the attraction level to account for any potential serial correlation in our panel data (Bertrand et al., 2004). ε_{it} is the idiosyncratic error term.

Table 3. Impact of home sharing on customer experience.

D.V. = attraction experience	(1)
log Home Share	0.072*** (0.003)
Attraction FE	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes
Observations	26,854
R ²	0.214

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

6 Estimation and Findings

In this section, we present our empirical findings. A quick roadmap of the analyses is as follows. In Section 6.1, we estimate the impact of home sharing on customer experience. We then drill down to the mechanism behind the impact in Section 6.2 by investigating the local travel support of hosts. In Section 6.3, we discuss the unintended consequence of home sharing on attraction with a focus on overtourism.

6.1 Impacts of Home Sharing on Attraction Customer Experience

We first examine the impact of home sharing on customer experience at attractions, as illustrated in H1. Table 3 presents the estimated effect, which shows that the coefficient of home sharing is positive and statistically significant. Specifically, for each 10% increase in home sharing supply, there is a 0.72 growth in customer experience at the affected attractions relative to the unaffected attractions. Considering the average review ratings (our measure of customer experience) range from 1 to 5, the increase of 0.72 in the average review ratings represents a 14.4% increase on a 5-star scale and is not trivial. As a result, H1 is supported.

6.2 Mechanisms Behind the Impact of Home Sharing

We have established that home sharing leads to an improved customer experience at attractions. To investigate the underlying mechanism, we dive into the central components of

home sharing's service operation: the hosts. We first examine whether host presence in home sharing properties leads to an enhanced customer experience through a moderation analysis and a comparison analysis between home sharing properties with host presence and without host presence. For a deeper understanding of host presence, we then employ text mining techniques to decompose host support into three unique aspects and replicate the comparison analyses. For each of the host support aspects, we explore its respective effect in affecting customer experience and whether an effect magnifies in home sharing properties with host presence.

6.2.1 Analyses of the Host Presence. We conjecture in H2 that the customer experience management (through host support) would more likely occur in face-to-face interactions. A useful characteristic of our data is that the Xiaozhu platform provides information on whether a host lives in the same home sharing property with consumers, i.e., a shared property. Thus, we seek to use whether a host is present and stays with consumers in a home sharing property as a proxy for the likelihood of face-to-face communications between hosts and consumers. Because our unit of analysis is at the attraction level, we calculate the proportion of all shared properties in which hosts stay with consumers at an attraction. As defined in Table A2 in E-Companion, we use the median split to create a dummy variable *High Host Presence*, which indicates whether the attraction has a higher proportion of shared properties than the median of all attractions in a city. Then, we include *High Host Presence* as a moderator in estimating the impact of home sharing on customer experience. The premise is that if local travel support provided by hosts is an important driver of customer experience at attractions, attractions with a higher proportion of shared properties with host presence would be associated with an improved customer experience than those with a lower proportion of shared properties with host presence.

Results in Table 4 support H2. Column (1) shows that the estimate for the interaction between *High Host Presence* and *log Home Share* is positive and statistically significant. Specifically, for attractions with a higher proportion of properties with host presence, the average attraction rating by consumers improves by 0.81 ($\approx (0.051 + 0.030) \times 10$) on a 5-star scale with a 10% increase in the home sharing supply.

To provide further evidence about host presence, we divided the independent variable (*log Home Share*) into two variables: *log Home Share with Host Presence* and *log Home Share without Host Presence*. This allows us to distinguish attractions by the number of active home sharing properties with host presence or without host presence. This differentiation provides another clear understanding of the role of host presence. Column (2) of Table 4 presents the results. It shows that customer experience at attractions with host presence in home sharing properties is significantly positive. However, customer experience at attractions without any host presence in home sharing properties, though still positive, is not significant. Taken together, evidence from Columns (1) and (2) of

Table 4. Impact of home sharing on customer experience by host presence.

D.V. = attraction experience	(1)	(2)
<i>log Home Share</i>	0.051*** (0.006)	
<i>log Home Share</i> $\times$ <i>High Host Presence</i>	0.030*** (0.007)	
<i>log Home Share with Host Presence</i>		0.087*** (0.008)
<i>log Home Share without Host Presence</i>		0.016 (0.010)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes
Observations	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.215	0.216

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses. *High Host Presence* is a time-invariant variable and has been omitted by Attraction FE.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

Table 4 both suggest that home sharing properties with host presence positively impact customer experience at attractions.

6.2.2 Analyses of the Specific Host Support. Recall that our conjectures in H3 specify the type of host support that improves customer experience at attractions. If host support is indeed a driving force behind the increased customer experience at attractions, we would expect the individual aspects of host support to follow along the same conjectured direction. We classify these aspects as follows: *Saving Tips* refers to host-provided advice on saving money and time while touring attractions; *Attraction Knowledge* involves the host's introduction to the historical and cultural beauty of attractions; and *Travel Planning* pertains to host consultations that help travelers plan trips tailored to their needs. These aspects are measured by the ratio of home sharing reviews depicting each specific aspect.⁴ Using these measures, we estimate their respective impacts on customer experience at attractions.

For the model specification in Table 5, we replace the main independent variable (*log home sharing*) with the ratio of each type of host support to examine the impact of host support on the attraction experience. Since host support emerges only when home sharing properties are introduced to an attraction, this specification remains consistent with our main DID design but without duplication from using *log home share*. It allows for a clear and precise interpretation of the impact of each type of host support. Across the three columns in Table 5, we can see a consistent pattern: for every 10% increase in each type of host support ratio, there is an increase in customer experience by 1.2, 0.8, and 1.0 on a 5-star scale, respectively. These results indicate that host support in terms of saving tips, attraction knowledge, and travel planning are significant drivers of customer experiences. H3 is supported.

Similar to the variable setup in Column (2) of Table 4, we further divided each of the three types of host support into two

Table 5. Impact of host support types on attraction experience.

D.V. = attraction experience	(1)	(2)	(3)
<i>Saving Tips Ratio</i>	0.122*** (0.038)		
<i>Attraction Knowledge Ratio</i>		0.089*** (0.025)	
<i>Travel Planning Ratio</i>			0.100*** (0.042)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
City-specific Trends	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	26,854	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.199	0.199	0.200

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

measures of host presence, as shown in Table 6. For example, for *Saving Trip*, we generate a new pair of measures. *Saving Tips Ratio with Host Presence* refers to the ratio of home sharing reviews depicting saving tips over all home sharing reviews for properties with host presence at the attraction level. Conversely, *Saving Tips Ratio without Host Presence* refers to the ratio of home sharing reviews depicting saving tips over all home sharing reviews for properties without host presence at the attraction level. Similarly, the other two types of host support, *Attraction Knowledge* and *Travel Planning*, are decomposed into such a pair of measures based on the presence or absence of the host. Similar to the model specification of Table 5, we use the specific type of host support with and without host presence as the independent variables without duplication from using *log home share*, which is also consistent with our DID design framework.

Our findings in Table 6 indicate that all three types of host support significantly enhance customer experience at attractions, regardless of host presence. Yet, attractions with the three aspects of host support from properties with host presence have stronger impacts on customer experience than those without host presence. Specifically, according to Column (1), the coefficient of $1 \text{ (After)} \times \text{Saving Tips Ratio with Host Presence}$ is 0.422, while the coefficient of $1 \text{ (After)} \times \text{Saving Tips Ratio without Host Presence}$ is 0.306. A F -test comparison ($F(1, 26,408) = 6.13$, $Prob > F = 0.014$) indicates that host support in saving tips from properties with host presence has a stronger impact on attraction experience than those without host presence. Similarly, the other two types of host support from properties with host presence show stronger impacts compared to those without host presence, as evidenced by the F -test results, i.e., $F(1, 26,408) = 4.17$, $Prob > F = 0.041$ for the coefficient comparison in Column (2), and $F(1, 26,408) = 10.90$, $Prob > F = 0.001$ for the coefficient comparison in Column (3). Collectively, these findings provide direct evidence of the unique role that home sharing plays in improving customer experience at attractions. While prior literature suggests that home sharing stays offer enhanced interactions

Table 6. Impact of host support types on attraction experience by host presence.

D.V. = attraction experience	(1)	(2)	(3)
<i>Saving Tips Ratio with Host Presence</i>	0.422*** (0.132)		
<i>Saving Tips Ratio without Host Presence</i>	0.306*** (0.066)		
<i>Attraction Knowledge Ratio with Host Presence</i>		0.199*** (0.057)	
<i>Attraction Knowledge Ratio without Host Presence</i>		0.138*** (0.040)	
<i>Travel Planning Ratio with Host Presence</i>			0.307*** (0.98)
<i>Travel Planning Ratio without Host Presence</i>			0.179*** (0.065)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes	YES
Observations	26,854	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.199	0.199	0.200

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

with hosts, providing a unique experience, we are among the first to unveil the exact types of host support at play. Our text mining method, as introduced in Section 4.2, provides an analysis framework for decomposing host support by type.

6.3 Unintended Consequences of Home Sharing

Thus far, we have shown an overall positive impact of home sharing on customer experience at attractions. A natural question would be: will there be any negative impact of home sharing at attractions? We first observed the decrease in customer experience at nationally renowned attractions and peak seasons which tend to attract more consumer visits, a sign of overtourism. We then disclosed an inverted U-shaped relationship between attraction visits and customer experience through a mediating analysis. Our observation of home sharing's impact on attraction visits at nationally renowned attractions and peak season further attributes the source of decreased customer experience to attraction visits. Fortunately, we found local host support is particularly valuable in reducing the negative effects of home sharing on customer experience at attractions.

6.3.1 Customer Experience Mitigated at Nationally Renowned Attractions and During Peak Seasons. We first investigate the home sharing impact by attraction and season. As nationally renowned attractions and peak seasons generally attract

Table 7. Impact of home sharing on customer experience by attraction and season.

D.V. = attraction experience	(1)	(2)	(3)
<i>log Home Share</i>	0.074*** (0.003)	0.072*** (0.004)	0.074*** (0.004)
<i>log Home Share</i> × <i>National Attraction</i>	−0.056*** (0.011)		−0.058*** (0.011)
<i>log Home Share</i> × <i>Peak Season</i>		−0.020*** (0.004)	−0.021*** (0.004)
<i>Peak Season</i>		0.092*** (0.010)	0.093*** (0.010)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	26,854	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.214	0.212	0.217

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses. *National Attraction* is a time-invariant variable and has been omitted by Attraction FE.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

a larger number of visitors compared to local gems and off-seasons, we are interested in understanding whether the impact of home sharing on customer experience remains the same across attractions and seasons. Table 7 presents the results. As Column (1) shows, the positive impact of home sharing on customer experience significantly weakens at nationally renowned attractions by 0.56 with a 10% increase in home sharing supply.

Similarly, Column (2) shows a significant decline in the positive impact of home sharing on customer experiences during peak seasons. Both findings suggest that home sharing may benefit the attractions at a cost. If home sharing continues to increase attraction visits at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons, this massive influx of consumers may decrease customer experience. Some people also call this phenomenon overtourism (Mihalic, 2020). Column (3) provides a joint model with both moderation terms included for a robustness check.

6.3.2 Evidence of Overtourism. To validate our prediction on overtourism, we continue to investigate the change in customer experience as attraction visits continue to increase. Table 8 presents the results. Column (1) demonstrates that home sharing indeed leads to an increase in attraction visits. When incorporating a quadratic term of the attraction visits in Column (2), we observed an inverted U-shaped curvilinear relationship between attraction visits and customer experience. That is, excessive visits (in the form of quadratic visits, *log Attraction Visits*²) result in a decline in customer experience. Additionally, Column (2) reveals a mediation effect of attraction visits on the relationship between home sharing and customer experience. Importantly, this mediation effect is not linear but follows an inverted U-shape. This means that home

Table 8. Mediation analyses of the impact of attraction visits on attraction experience.

D.V.	(1) <i>log Attraction Visits</i>	(2) <i>Attraction experience</i>
<i>log Home Share</i>	0.157*** (0.007)	0.050*** (0.004)
<i>log Attraction Visits</i>		0.017*** (0.007)
<i>log Attraction Visits</i> ²		−0.005*** (0.001)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes
City-specific Trends	Yes	Yes
Observations	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.203	0.218

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

sharing increases visits, which in turn impacts customer experience; when visits reach a certain threshold, the increased visits begin to negatively affect customer experience. Taken together, the results suggest home sharing may cause unintended consequences with a burden of overtourism at the cost of consumer experience at local attractions.

To further observe the increased attraction visits, we explored the impact of home sharing on attraction visits. The results are shown in Table 9. Given that Table 8 shows that home sharing indeed brings more visits to attractions, Columns (1) and (2) in Table 9 further show that such an effect is more pronounced at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons compared to local gems and off-seasons. These results further point to overtourism at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons, shedding light on excessive visits as the main driving force behind the decreased customer experience at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons, as shown in Table 7.

6.3.3 Host Support Addressing Overtourism. We have discussed extensively host support as an important channel of customer experience management. If host support indeed elevates customer experience, will it help mitigate the overtourism issue at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons? We raise this conjecture in H4 and now obtain evidence to address it. The results are presented in Tables 10 and 11.

As shown in Table 10, we disaggregate the key independent variable *log Home Share* into two categories: *log Home Share with Host Presence* and *log Home Share without Host Presence*. We found non-significant coefficients of *log Home Share with Host Presence* × *National Attraction* per Column (1) and *log Home Share with Host Presence* × *Peak Season* per Column (2). It is intriguing that the once negative moderating effects of nationally renowned attractions and peak seasons on customer experience shown in Table 7 have

Table 9. Impact of home sharing on attraction visits by attraction and season.

D.V. = <i>log Attraction Visits</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)
<i>log Home Share</i>	0.121*** (0.007)	0.134*** (0.007)	0.098*** (0.007)
<i>log Home Share</i> × <i>National Attraction</i>	0.957*** (0.049)		0.957*** (0.048)
<i>log Home Share</i> × <i>Peak Season</i>		0.070*** (0.011)	0.070*** (0.011)
<i>Peak Season</i>		0.103*** (0.031)	0.097*** (0.030)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	26,854	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.566	0.554	0.569

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses. *National Attraction* is a time-invariant variable and has been omitted by Attraction FE.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

Table 10. Impact of home sharing on customer experience by host presence. Across attractions and seasons.

D.V. = <i>attraction experience</i>	(1)	(2)
<i>log Home Share with Host Presence</i>	0.090*** (0.008)	0.081*** (0.008)
<i>log Home Share without Host Presence</i>	0.017 (0.010)	0.008 (0.010)
<i>log Home Share with Host Presence</i> × <i>National Attraction</i>	−0.028 (0.020)	
<i>log Home Share without Host Presence</i> × <i>National Attraction</i>	−0.070*** (0.018)	
<i>log Home Share with Host Presence</i> × <i>Peak Season</i>		0.007 (0.011)
<i>log Home Share without Host Presence</i> × <i>Peak Season</i>		−0.026*** (0.008)
<i>Peak Season</i>		0.092*** (0.010)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	26,854	26,854
R ²	0.215	0.217

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses. *National Attraction* is a time-invariant variable and has been omitted by Attraction FE.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

now become non-significant for attractions with home sharing properties that have host presence. This result indicates that local host support is particularly valuable in reducing the negative effects specific to overtourism at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons, supporting the role of

host support as the mechanism for enhancing customer experiences despite overtourism.⁵ To gain a deeper understanding of how local host support effectively mitigates overtourism, we further examined the role of local host support in directing visits and improving experiences amid overtourism at nationally renowned attractions (Table 11, panel A) and during peak seasons (Table 11, panel B). For easier interpretation of the results, we use a sub-sample approach (rather than a three-way interaction), in which attractions are divided into two groups based on whether they are nationally renowned or local gems (Table 11, panel A) and seasons are divided into two groups based on whether they are peak seasons or off-peak seasons (Table 11, panel B).

Columns (1) and (2) in Table 11 (panel A) indicate that host presence significantly enhances the impact of home sharing on customer experience for both local gems and nationally famous attractions. However, the moderating effect of host presence on the impact of home sharing on attraction visits exhibits interesting heterogeneity between the two groups. While home sharing results in an overall increase in attraction visits, host presence amplifies this positive effect for local gems but diminishes it for nationally renowned attractions. As Column (3) shows, local hosts tend to direct visits to less-known local gem attractions that are not widely advertised or publicized toward an increase in visits to those attractions. Such redirection of visits to local gems tends to provide consumers with a more authentic and unique experience, highlighting the added value of host presence. Relatedly, while host presence enhances visits to local gems, it tends to divert visits away from more well-known attractions, resulting in a significantly weakened impact of home sharing on visits to nationally famous attractions in Column (4).

Such contrasting findings point to the interesting differential impacts of host presence at two types of attractions. Specifically, local hosts play a pivotal role in enhancing the appeal of local gems. By offering personalized recommendations and directing visitors to lesser-known spots that are not widely publicized, hosts significantly amplify the impact of home sharing on visits to local gems. This highlights the unique ability of local hosts to cater to the growing demand for genuine and personalized travel experiences, which are less readily available at nationally renowned attractions. Moreover, beyond providing basic assistance such as saving tips, attraction knowledge, and planning information, local hosts add substantial value by offering deeper cultural insights and introducing travelers to off-the-beaten-path locations. These efforts allow visitors to experience the local charm in a way that guidebooks or online platforms cannot replicate, making visits to local gems more immersive and meaningful. In contrast, the standardized and often commercialized experiences at nationally renowned attractions limit the potential for such personalized engagement, which may explain why host presence has a weaker effect on these sites. Together, these insights underscore how host support not only enhances the visitor experience at local gems but also shifts tourism flows away

Table 11. Impact of home sharing on customer experience and attraction visits by host presence across attractions and seasons.

	(1) <i>Attraction experience</i>	(2)	(3) <i>log Attraction Visits</i>	(4)
Panel A	Nationally Famous Attractions		Nationally Famous Attractions	
Panel A	Local Gems	Nationally Famous Attractions	Local Gems	Nationally Famous Attractions
<i>log Home Share</i>	0.046*** (0.008)	0.033*** (0.011)	0.083*** (0.012)	0.310*** (0.026)
<i>log Home Share × High Host Presence</i>	0.034*** (0.009)	0.056*** (0.013)	0.064*** (0.014)	−0.170*** (0.028)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	17,634	9220	17,634	9220
R ²	0.223	0.190	0.468	0.692
Panel B	Off-peak Season	Peak Season	Off-peak Season	Peak Season
<i>log Home Share</i>	0.063*** (0.008)	0.038*** (0.010)	0.142*** (0.016)	0.190*** (0.020)
<i>log Home Share × High Host Presence</i>	0.024*** (0.010)	0.035*** (0.011)	0.022*** (0.009)	−0.043*** (0.012)
Attraction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
City-specific trends	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	22,067	4787	22,067	4787
R ²	0.225	0.234	0.572	0.573

Note. Clustered robust standard errors in parentheses. *High Host Presence* is a time-invariant variable and has been omitted by Attraction FE.

* $p < .1$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

from overburdened national landmarks. This redirection balances the benefits of home sharing between different attraction types, mitigating the challenges of overtourism while fostering more sustainable and rewarding travel experiences.

Similarly, we replicate this analysis by categorizing seasons into peak and off-peak, with results presented in Table 11, panel B. While host presence increases significantly the customer experience for both seasons as shown in Columns (1) and (2) of Table 11, panel B, it effectively increases visits during off-peak seasons per Column (3) and alleviate surge visits during peak seasons per Column (4). This effect aligns with the idea that local hosts actively help balance traffic flows across seasons, enhancing customer experience during both peak and low-demand times.

In sum, the findings in Table 11, panels A and B, provide consistent evidence in support of H4. Local host support not only enhances customer experience but also mitigates the negative effects of overtourism by redistributing visitor traffic toward local gems and off-peak times. This nuanced understanding of host support highlights its unique contribution to balancing tourist demand and improving overall visitor satisfaction across both nationally renowned and lesser-known attractions, especially in contexts where overtourism concerns are pronounced.

7 Additional Analyses

To strengthen our main results, we furnished a rich set of analyses to rule out alternative explanations and check the robustness of our findings. We incorporated these additional analyses in the E-Companion and summarized them as follows.

7.1 Ruling out Alternative Explanations

7.1.1 Reverse Causality. Some may be concerned that the roll-out of home sharing is subject to reverse causality. We utilize a logit hazard model to examine attraction characteristics that may affect the rollout of home sharing. The results are presented in Table A4 of Section A4.1 in the E-Companion. While certain attraction characteristics can influence home sharing rollout, we found the coefficient of historical attraction experience (*Cum. Attraction Experience*) is not significantly associated with the rollout of home sharing, which provides insights into the absence of reverse causality. That is, the roll-out of home sharing is exogenous with respect to customer experience.

7.1.2 Changes in Customer Base. Some may wonder if home sharing would change the customer base who leaves reviews. If so, the changes in the customer base may confound the impact of home sharing on customer experience. We check the change in the customer base by comparing their attraction

review writing patterns in terms of review topics before and after the rollout of home sharing. We present a topic modeling process explaining the extraction of attraction review topics in Section 4.2 of the E-Companion. Table A5 in Section 5.2 presents summarized topics and the top 10 keywords associated with each topic. The results in Table A6 in Section A4.2 show the customer base, as observed in the way they write attraction reviews, does not change significantly before and after the rollout of home sharing.

7.1.3 Placebo Tests. Some random or pre-treatment events rather than home sharing may drive the changes in the attraction experience. To rule out this alternative explanation, we conduct two placebo tests. First, we follow a random placebo treatment approach (Chao and Larkin, 2022) to randomly assign a subset of unaffected attractions as if they were affected by home sharing. The results are presented in Figure A1 of Section A4.3 in the E-Companion. We found that the “counterfactual” treatment constructed in the simulations does not affect the attraction experience. Second, we adopt a pre-treatment placebo treatment approach through which we use only the pre-treatment data to implement a placebo treatment three months before the actual treatment. Table A7 in Section A4.4 provides the result of this analysis. The estimated effect of the placebo treatment is statistically insignificant, indicating the placebo effect is null. This null effect in the pretreatment period enhances the plausibility of our common trends assumption.

7.2 Robustness Checks

7.2.1 Relative Time Model. We adopt the relative time model to check whether the parallel trends assumption holds for the affected and unaffected attractions in our DID design. Section A5.1 in the E-Companion exhibits the model specification. Figure A2 of Section A5.1 in the E-Companion shows the parallel trends of the relative time model. There is no significant pre-treatment difference between groups, validating the DID assumption.

7.2.2 Alternative Measures of Home Sharing. In the main analyses, home sharing is measured by the logarithm of the number of active home sharing properties within a 5-kilometer vicinity of an attraction. For robustness, we use three types of alternative measures for home sharing and replicate the main analyses using these measures. First, we define home sharing using various attraction vicinity including 1-kilometer, 5-kilometer, and 10-kilometer. Table A8 in Section A5.2 of the E-Companion presents observations in affected and unaffected groups using these radii. Table A9 in Section A5.2 of the E-Companion presents the statistics of the measures using these radii. Table A10 in Section A5.2 of the E-Companion presents the results. Second, we also use a binary variable, *1(After)*, to check the robustness of the estimated impact in Section A5.3. Table A11 in Section A5.3 of the E-Companion presents the

results. Lastly, we used the lagged *log Home Share* to measure home sharing and re-ran the main analysis shown in Table A12 of Section A5.4 of the E-Companion. All of these results remain the same as our main findings, lending support to the robustness of our findings.

7.2.3 Look-Ahead Propensity Score Matching. As an alternative specification, we adopted a Look-Ahead Propensity Score Matching (LA-PSM) to complement our main specification using DID with a PSM sample. The main idea is to use attractions that are treated in the latter part of our sample period to serve as the control units as shown in Figure A3 of Section A5.5 in the E-Companion. In this way, we made sure that the control group also eventually has home sharing properties around them to reduce the concern about the geographic difference. We reported the balance check of covariates in the LA-PSM sample shown in Table A13 and the estimated results using the LA-PSM sample shown in Table A14 of Section A5.5 in the E-Companion. The results remained consistent between the LA-PSM sample and the main DID sample.

7.2.4 Instrumental Variable Approach. To triangulate the estimated impact of home sharing, we utilized changes in home sharing reviews as our instrument and re-run the analysis. The variable of home sharing reviews is an effective instrument variable because (a) these reviews are significantly correlated with the supply of home sharing during that same period (the relevance condition) and (b) these reviews are randomly contributed by consumers and should not be related to attraction customer experience unless through the home sharing supply (the exclusion condition). The results are presented in Table A15 of Section A5.6 in the E-Companion and provide further support to the main findings.

7.2.5 Heterogeneous Treatment Effects. Some may be concerned that attractions affected by the home sharing rollout at different times could exhibit heterogeneous treatment effects. We followed de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeuille (2020) by adopting their estimation method, a.k.a. the CD estimator, to address this concern. The detailed results are reported in Figure A4 of Section A5.7 in the E-Companion. We found the results, using the CD estimator, to be highly consistent with our original DID estimates.

7.2.6 Additional Control Variables. We included additional controls to ensure the robustness of the results. These controls include the number of attraction visits, the number of attraction reviews, the lagged cumulative average attraction experience, the search volumes of attractions, and other three home sharing platforms (i.e., Tujia, Muniao, and Airbnb China), the purchase-verified hotel stays near each attraction, peak season, and the perceived home sharing price at each attraction. The results are shown in Table A16 of Section A5.8 in the E-Companion, which are consistent with the main findings.

7.2.7 Alternative Heterogeneous Analysis. To provide an alternative heterogeneity analysis, we explored how the impact of home sharing on customer experience varies by attraction density (a proxy for travel options). The results are presented in Table A17 of Section A5.9 in the E-Companion. We found that host support significantly enhances customer experience at attractions with a higher density of travel options, lending support to the mechanism of host support behind the impact of home sharing on the attraction experience.

8 Conclusion and Implications

The sharing economy has emerged as a viable alternative to incumbent counterparts, and its impact continues to grow in local markets. Our findings suggest that home sharing can be a catalyst for increased customer reach at attractions while strengthening the customer experience. Centric on the theory of customer experience management, this paper investigates an important yet under-explored role of home sharing in changing not only the way customers travel but also their experience at attractions. Our results show that home sharing has a generally positive impact on the attraction experience, which manifests through local host support such as providing saving tips, attraction knowledge, and travel planning. However, while home sharing attracts more visits to attractions, unintended consequences of home sharing would occur to nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons. Fortunately, local host support is a valuable approach to mitigate overtourism for nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons. These findings speak on customer experience management through host support and provide a holistic picture of the role of home sharing in terms of its positive influence on attraction experience, unintended consequences of overtourism, and important values of its host support in mitigating overtourism.

8.1 Theoretical Implications

Our findings contribute primarily to the literature on customer experience management. Customer experience, which is considered the fundamental basis for service operation, has attracted remarkable attention over the past decade (Becker and Jaakkola, 2020). Despite a growing interest in customer experience in service operations, limited research has provided insight into how service providers (local hosts in our case) affect customer experience. This study bridges the gap by investigating the impact of home sharing on the attraction experience and the mechanism of host support behind the impact. Our findings unveil host support as an important channel of customer experience management and can greatly elevate the customer experience at attractions. Particularly, the application of text mining helps us drill down to specific aspects of host support that enhance customer experience, introducing new strategies of customer experience management specific to the sharing economy context. As the first

group of research to examine customer experience management in home sharing from the perspective of host support, we have made clear the importance of empowering local hosts given the evidence that home sharing hosts have the potential to shape consumer experience.

Different from prior literature that focuses on the average impact of home sharing (Lalicic et al., 2021; Shi et al., 2019), our study unveils how customer experience varies at different attractions and during different seasons. Such heterogeneity not only demonstrates the nuances of home sharing's impact under variant market conditions but also pinpoints the unintended consequences of overtourism especially at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons. As home sharing continues to grow, we are among the first to empirically disclose the overtourism issues along with the penetration of home sharing into local markets. Our multifaceted evidence that excessive visits may mitigate home sharing's positive impact on customer experience, particularly at nationally renowned attractions and peak seasons, adds empirical insights to anecdotal evidence on home sharing and overtourism.

By uncovering the potential backfiring effects of home sharing, our study emphasizes the need for a more cautious assessment of its impact, in contrast to a literature base that often emphasizes only its positive effects (Alyakoob and Rahman, 2022). In acknowledging the overtourism issue associated with home sharing, we proactively explore solutions through customer experience management, identifying host support as a valuable tool for mitigating these negative effects. Our finding that local host support can alleviate the drawbacks of home sharing by redistributing visitor traffic and enhancing the experience at both popular and lesser-known sites sheds light on a previously underexplored role of service providers in managing unintended customer experience challenges. This insight not only provides a new understanding of the roles of home sharing hosts but also contributes to the literature on service operations with a specific focus on customer experience management in the sharing economy context.

8.2 Practical Implications

Our study provides new insights into service operations of attractions. While previous literature has largely focused on effective service operations from the perspective of operators (e.g., Murugesan et al., 2022), we propose a broader strategy: actively integrating local home sharing hosts into the operational ecosystem of attractions. This approach expands the operational ecosystem by engaging stakeholders beyond the attractions themselves. Our findings demonstrate that home sharing hosts play a crucial role in not only enhancing positive visitor experiences but also mitigating negative experiences—particularly at nationally renowned attractions and during peak seasons. Host support, such as offering savings tips, sharing knowledge about attractions, and helping guests plan their trips, directly aligns with the principles of customer

experience management and positively influences guest satisfaction, as reflected in home sharing reviews. Furthermore, local hosts play a crucial role in directing visits to local gems, thereby not only providing authentic experience at these less-known attractions but also diverting tourism flows from overburdened national landmarks. This strategic re-distribution of visits through home sharing benefits different types of attractions, addressing the challenges of overtourism and promoting more sustainable and fulfilling travel experiences.

To explore the feasibility of collaboration between attractions and home sharing hosts, one practical strategy involves bundled travel packages and joint promotions. Attractions and home sharing hosts can collaborate to offer “Stay & Play” packages, combining accommodation with exclusive access to attractions. For example, local hosts could bundle attraction tickets with early access or private tours of attractions with their home sharing stays. A similar model is already seen in Airbnb Experiences, where hosts collaborate with local businesses to provide unique activities and tours. Reciprocally, attractions could also partner with hosts to promote nearby sites or bundle tickets as part of their lodging offerings. For instance, attractions might offer discounted tickets, skip-the-line access, or private tours exclusively for guests staying at partnered properties. These collaborations enhance guest experiences, drive visitor traffic to attractions, and boost bookings for home sharing stays, creating a mutually beneficial relationship.

Another strategy is to provide host training and certification programs through which attractions can elevate service standards by training local hosts to become knowledgeable ambassadors. This involves equipping hosts with insights about events and travel packages offered by attractions, empowering them to represent the attractions through official recognition. A notable example is Japan’s tourism board programs, where certified hosts offer both lodging and cultural experiences, such as tea ceremonies and rural tours.⁶ Engaging local hosts in providing attraction-related experiences fosters a community spirit and personalizes interactions with visitors for a better experience at attractions.

Technology can greatly facilitate the partnership between attractions and home sharing communities. For example, attractions can work with technology companies to develop integrated booking systems that can enhance the collaboration between home sharing communities and attractions. Barcelona hosts, for example, package Park Güell and Sagrada Família tickets with their listings, offering guests a complete travel experience through one platform.⁷ WeChat mini-programs in China allow hosts to bundle tickets with accommodation in one-stop shopping. Additionally, introducing pilot programs for evidence-based assessment can help evaluate the feasibility and success of collaborations. During holiday seasons in New York City, for instance, home sharing communities could partner with Broadway shows or holiday markets to offer premier seats or exclusive shopping passes.⁸ Data from purchase-verified show watching or shopping can provide

insights into the performance of these collaborations, offering valuable guidance for refining long-term strategies.

Lastly, establishing collaborative governance with policy-maker engagement ensures that partnerships are supported by well-designed governance structures rather than restrictive policies. Local governments can offer tax incentives or grants to encourage partnerships between attractions and home sharing communities. To prevent overtourism while balancing the benefits of collaboration, attraction operators can work with policymakers to implement capacity management strategies, especially at nationally renowned attractions.

8.3 Limitations and Future Research Opportunities

Our research is not without limitations. First, the impacts of home sharing and its estimated impact on customer experience may be restricted to attractions and may not be generalized to other contexts. As home sharing continues to proliferate, future research can examine other businesses such as food services (e.g., restaurants and food delivery), retail (e.g., neighborhood shops), and other travel services (e.g., transportation) to further deepen our understanding of home sharing’s impact on local markets. This will not only generalize our research framework to other contexts but also provide interesting comparisons across the contexts. Second, our data was collected during a period of home sharing’s fast growth in China with minimal governance. As the regulatory stances from local governments continue to evolve, it is important to investigate the intervention of governance to home sharing’s impact on local markets. For instance, certain neighborhoods have rules on whether and to what extent the hosts can utilize their properties for home sharing. It will be interesting to explore the dynamics between home sharing and customer experience at attractions under regulatory pressure. Third, our home sharing data is limited to Xiaozhu, the largest and the earliest home sharing platform, without the coverage of other home sharing platforms (such as Tujia, Muniiao, and Airbnb China). Thus, our findings may not capture the full picture of the home sharing market. Despite us having controlled the search volumes at other platforms to address the lack of data, it is advocated that future researchers collect data from multiple platforms to further validate our findings. Finally, future research can continue to explore the dark side of home sharing and the sharing economy in local markets, providing more evidence-based findings to inform policymaking. We hope our study paves the way for future scholars to further their understanding of the role of home sharing in local markets.

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Notes

1. Managing Overcrowding in Tourism Destinations. Source: <https://shorturl.at/97Hon>, retrieved on June 23, 2024.
2. Source: <https://shorturl.at/HSM6>, retrieved on June 23, 2024.
3. Source: <https://shorturl.at/zXiCF>, retrieved on June 23, 2024.
4. We also conduct a robustness check using the incremental number of relevant reviews. The results in Table A18 of Section A4.10 in the E-Companion are consistent with our main results.
5. For robustness checks, we also replace the host presence measures using *High Host Presence*. The results are shown in Table A19 of Section A4.11 in the E-Companion and consistently suggest higher host presence can mitigate the negative moderating effects of nationally renowned attractions and peak seasons, which is consistent with the findings in Table 10.
6. Source: <https://shorturl.at/IgqpW>, retrieved on November 1, 2024.
7. Source: <https://shorturl.at/1nkZ5>, retrieved on November 1, 2024.
8. Source: <https://shorturl.at/gUed1>, retrieved on November 1, 2024.

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